

SIM-based hotspot devices: For such devices, you need to get a separate SIM card from an Internet service provider and insert into the Wi-Fi router. Then you will need to connect the router to your computer with a USB cable and configure it to use the SIM card in order to make a connection with the service provider. You may then disconnect it from your computer and use it as a Wi-Fi router. The pocket Wi-Fi router acts as a modem as well as Wi-Fi hotspot.

USB data card/modem-based Wi-Fi hotspot devices: In such cases, a USB-based data card is used and it needs to be connected to the Web. The USB data card is attached to the pocket Wi-Fi router to make an Internet connection. It is important to understand that these types of Wi-Fi hotspot devices do not have an in-built modem. They rely on the USB data card to connect to the Internet service provider.

USB dongles/data cards with the Wi-Fi hotspot option: There are a number of dongles available in the market that come with the built-in Wi-Fi hotspot option. So, you don't need to buy a separate device to share your Internet connection, which can prove to be cost-effective.

Evaluating a hotspot device

We reached out to various industry players to figure out what qualified as a good hotspot device. Jason Xu, director at TP-Link India, shares, "A good hotspot should do several things. First, it should be compatible with local ISPs to give end users as much choice as possible to select their carrier. Second, it should be compact (without sacrificing battery life) for maximum portability. And finally, end users should be able

to connect several users or devices to the hotspot, without impacting upload and download speeds too significantly. The number of devices that can be connected simultaneously should be such that members of a small team can all use the hotspot at the same time."

According to Anand Narang, marketing director, Consumer Devices Business group at Huawei India, from a user's perspective, all a person wants is a hotspot device that can simply provide reliable Internet connectivity anywhere and anytime, to multiple devices. "A good hotspot device must have the features that ensure 'simple, reliable, anywhere, any time' Internet access. The user must be clear about this factor before buying a hotspot device. For example, typical young users just want to enable the data card in their laptops to share the Internet connection with their tablets and smartphones. They do not want to use their smartphones as the hotspot, because the speed is not so good and the battery will burn out. So the best hotspot for such users is the Wi-Fi data card, which can not only work as the common data card but also as a Wi-Fi hotspot," opines Narang.

Reliable data coverage, speed and portability are the key factors to look for while buying a hotspot device, believes Anoop Jarial, VP, Product Marketing at D-Link (India) Ltd. "One needs to confirm the speed supported on WAN as well as on wireless, along with other factors like the number of users it supports, security features, power required by the device, etc. In addition to this, the price and the design of the product are also key deciding factors," says Jarial.

Some of the Wi-Fi hotspot devices available in the market

TP-LINK M5350

Equipped with a built-in 3G modem, one can instantly establish a Wi-Fi hotspot simply by inserting a 3G SIM card at the back of the device. With a 21.6 MBps download speed and 5.76 MBps upload speed, the M5350 is able to provide 3G wireless sharing to up to 10 users simultaneously. Its pocket-sized design and powerful 2000 mAh internal battery make it an ideal travel companion, allowing users to work or play for hours on end. With a compact case and innovative cobblestone design that features an embedded OLED display, the M5350 provides a much more intuitive view of the device's working status, such as signal strength, network type (2G/3G), Wi-Fi status, messages received, Internet connection status, battery meter, connection mode and traffic statistics.

The M5350 is equipped with a micro SD card slot that supports cards with a capacity of up to 32 GB, allowing users to insert a micro SD card and plug the device into a PC to use it as an external USB memory stick.



Price: ₹ 5,499